

Post Covid Learning Assessment of 4000 Children

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Submitted by

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Introduction

Education is a necessity in today's society. Over the years both before and after independence many schools have been built in urban as well as in the rural areas. Though, before independence much less women had access to education than that of after independence. However, despite the increasing number of schools, the number of educated children is much lesser. This is not because of one single cause. There are many concerning situations or reasons which prevents a student from getting the proper education they deserve.

The situation got even worse after the breakdown of Covid-19 epidemic. All institutions were closed for a long period of time in order to prevent spread of the virus. And after things started to catch up many students were seen getting progressively worse in their studies and many of them even dropping out of institutions. By analyzing the statistics, we can call out to the situation and proceed to get help to make a better world.

Aim of the Project

To assess the learning level of 4000 children in the post Covid situation in the age group of 7 to 14 years in four geographical locations of Jammu & Kashmir, Jharkhand, West Bengal and Manipur.

Scope

- CRY- Child Rights and You in collaboration with RILM (Rotary India Literacy Mission) is implementing a project for child development in selected areas of CRY implementation operational area and to use the findings as baseline analysis.
- There was a series of debate and discussion at various level about the learning gaps of the children during Covid, but there were no sufficient evidences to come in conclusion “ How Much” and “How far children impacted”. Findings will help in reframe the education intervention.

Dataset

A dataset is achieved from a survey made by 50 field workers who were part of the assessment and were trained by RILM. The dataset consists of the education status of 4000 children. Children were assessed basis three indicators- status of children (drop out, never enrolled and laggard), learning not as per the age-appropriate class, reading and basic calculation competency. The survey took place in the months of June – July in the year 2022. Each and every children have been provided with the books of age-appropriate class to test the competency in reading and basic calculation. As per the ability of the children, teachers scored the children with the level of learning. Data compiled for all 4000 children with age-appropriate class and learning level of children. Our survey covered a few number of institutions in each of the four states namely, Jammu and Kashmir, Jharkhand, Manipur and West Bengal.

Certain details like name of a child and their mother's name have not been brought out. Instead, they are shown as child 1, child 2... for the children names and Mother-1, Mother-2... for the names of their mother. The three tables shown is the dataset that we have worked with consisting of all the details of the children.

Table 1

Sl. No.	Center	Child Name	Sex	Date of Birth	Mother's name	Category of the child	Age-appropriate class
1	ASHA KIRAN CENTER KULHAMA	child 1	FEMALE	8/5/2013	Mother-1	LAGGARD	2
2	ASHA KIRAN CENTER KULHAMA	child 2	FEMALE	5/13/2013	Mother-2	LAGGARD	3
3	ASHA KIRAN CENTER KULHAMA	child 3	FEMALE	2/4/2010	Mother-3	LAGGARD	6
4	ASHA KIRAN CENTER KULHAMA	child 4	FEMALE	2/2/2014	Mother-4	LAGGARD	2
5	ASHA KIRAN CENTER KULHAMA	child 5	FEMALE	2/2/2014	Mother-5	LAGGARD	2

Table 2

Sl. No.	Village / Ward / Street	Block	Gram Panchayat / City	District	State	Parent's occupation
1	KULHAMA	BANDIPORA	NADIHAL B	BANDIPORA	JAMMU AND KASHMIR	FISHERMAN
2	KULHAMA	BANDIPORA	NADIHAL B	BANDIPORA	JAMMU AND KASHMIR	FISHERMAN
3	KULHAMA	BANDIPORA	NADIHAL B	BANDIPORA	JAMMU AND KASHMIR	FISHERMAN
4	KULHAMA	BANDIPORA	NADIHAL B	BANDIPORA	JAMMU AND KASHMIR	FISHERMAN
5	KULHAMA	BANDIPORA	NADIHAL B	BANDIPORA	JAMMU AND KASHMIR	FISHERMAN

Table 3

Sl. No.	Category	Reading ability	Basic calculation	compatibility reading level	compatibility basic calculation level	Reason for not going to school
1	OBC	EXCELLENT	MODERATE	1	1	NA
2	GENERAL	GOOD	MODERATE	2	1	LACK OF PARENTAL CONCERN
3	GENERAL	GOOD	MODERATE	2	2	MOTHERS DEATH
4	GENERAL	MODERATE	MODERATE	1	1	LACK OF PARENTAL CONCERN
5	GENERAL	MODERATE	MODERATE	1	1	LACK OF PARENTAL CONCERN

Basic information about the children's profile:

- Age group covered- 7 to 14 years
- Total children screened- 4000
- Total Male- 1884
- Total Female- 2116
- Total States – 4
- Villages covered- 40

Locations covered:

States	Districts	Blocks	No. of Panchayats
Jammu & Kashmir	Bandipora	Sambal, Bandipora, Hajin	09
West Bengal	Jalpaiguri	Banarhat	04
Jharkhand	Koderma	Satgawa	02
Manipur	Imphal West	Haorang Sabal, Patsoi	08

Child coverage over the places:

States	Districts	No. of centres	No. of children
Jammu & Kashmir	Bandipora	09	565
West Bengal	Jalpaiguri	15	1735
Jharkhand	Koderma	06	700
Manipur	Imphal West	09	1000
Total	04	39	4000

Child Coverage in states

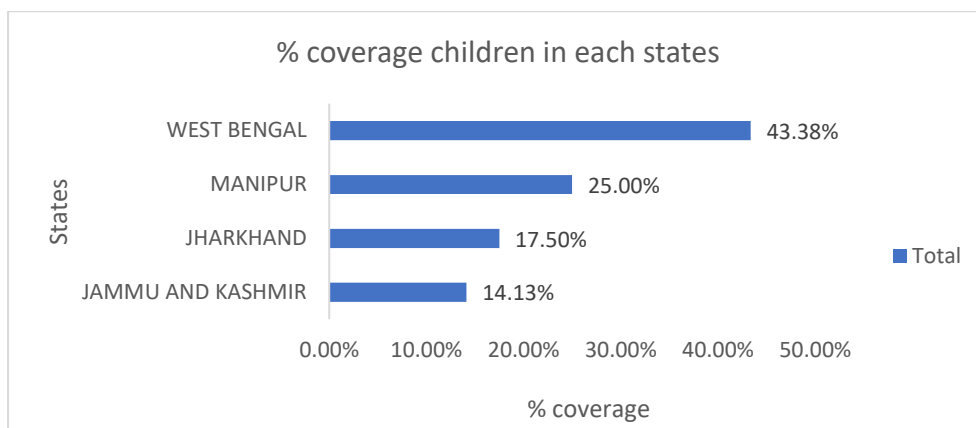


Figure 1

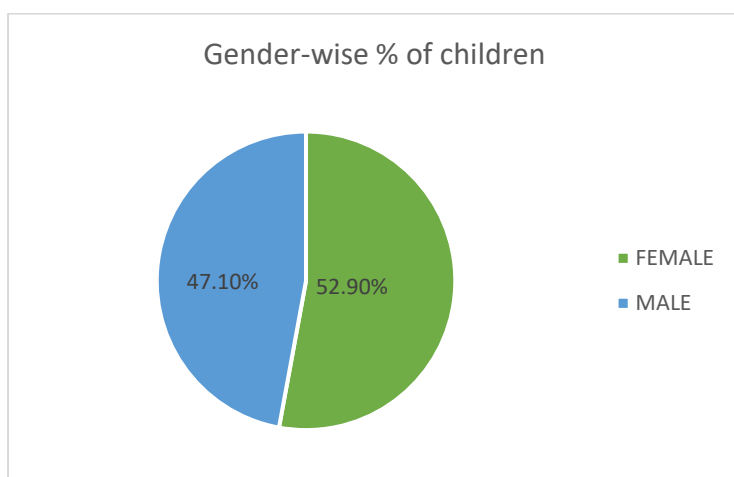


Figure 2

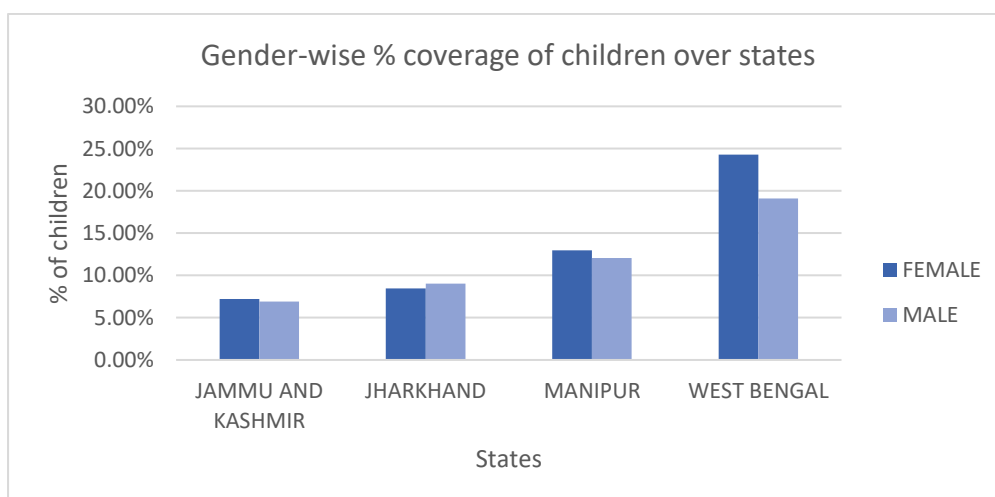


Figure 3

Figure 1 shows the % coverage of children (that have taken part in our surveys) in the four mentioned states and the result shows that West Bengal has the highest

count. Figure 2 is a pie diagram representing the gender wise distribution of the children. Figure 3 represents the gender wise percentage of children in the different states which is a combination of both the information we gathered from figure 1 and 2.

Categorical Distribution

Table 4

States	Categories				Grand Total
	GENERAL	OBC	SC	ST	
JAMMU AND KASHMIR	345	220			565
JHARKHAND	40	262	395	3	700
MANIPUR	971	29			1000
WEST BENGAL	22	227	200	1286	1735
Grand Total	1378	738	595	1289	4000

% of children according to their categorical distributions

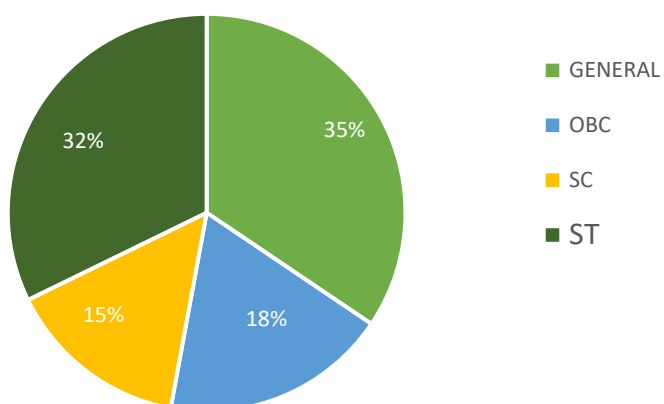


Figure 4

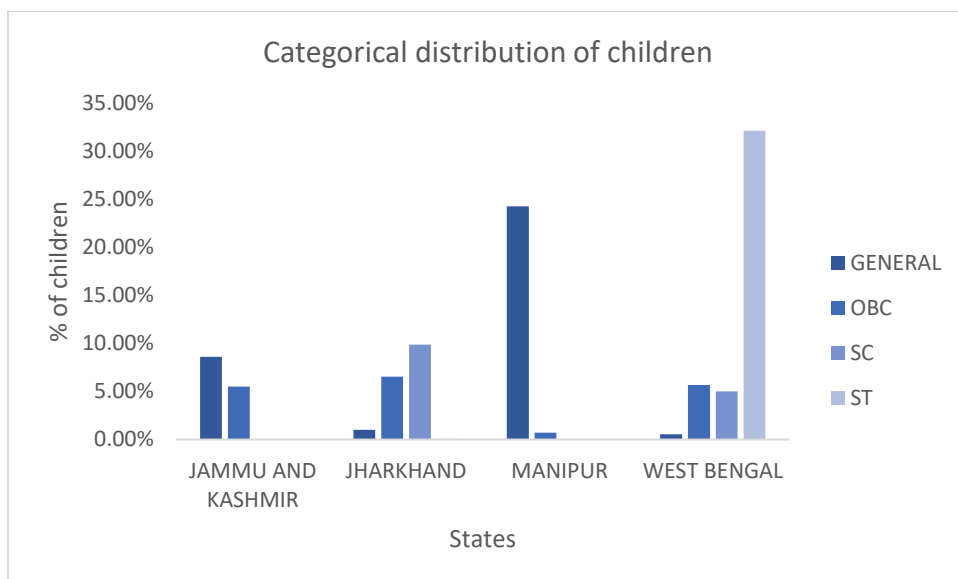


Figure 5

Table 1 represents the categorical division (General, OBC, SC, ST) among the children over the different states. Figures 4 and 5 are used to represent the same information diagrammatically. With the help of figure 5, we see that West Bengal has the highest proportion of ST category, which is much higher than any other categories in West Bengal whereas General category is the minimal. This is an observation which is to be noted as many institutions or organizations have certain amount of reservations made for distinguished caste categories. This may come as a hindrance for there may be some students who may not get an opportunity even though they are deserving.

Enrolment Status

The enrolment status of the children can be divided into three categories – ‘dropout’, ‘laggard’ and ‘never enrolled’. Dropouts are referred to those students who have stopped attending schools or got their names withdrawn from the schools for last one year. These students did not want to continue with their studies which maybe due to the covid-19 breakdown or any other reason. The students who are behind their age-appropriate classes are represented in the ‘laggard’ category. In this project we will broadly deal with the students belonging to this category. The children coming under the category of ‘never enrolled’ were not enrolled in any school or institution in the first place. This may be a situation due to poverty or in some cases negligence of parents. The table below shows the count of children classified each of the categories mentioned in each of the states.

Table 5

States	Enrolment status			Grand Total
	DROP OUT	LAGGARD	NEVER ENROLLED	
JAMMU AND KASHMIR	95	366	104	565
JHARKHAND	15	684	1	700
MANIPUR	36	963	1	1000
WEST BENGAL	10	1719	6	1735
Grand Total	156	3732	112	4000

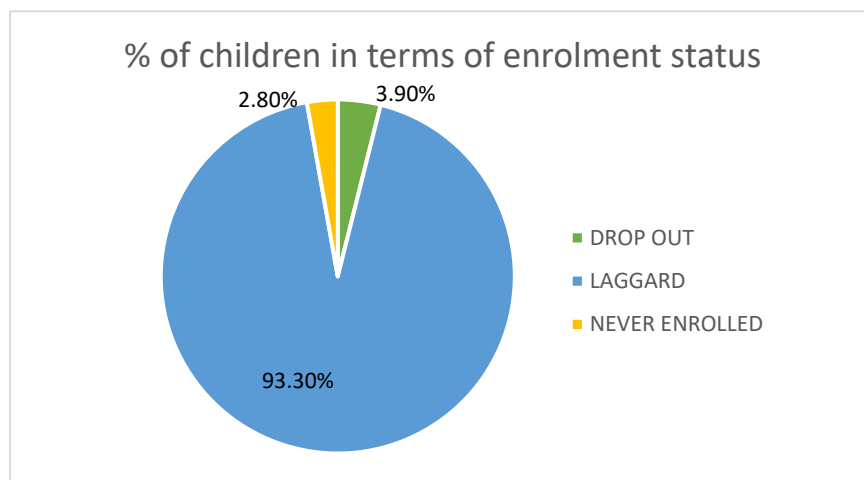


Figure 6

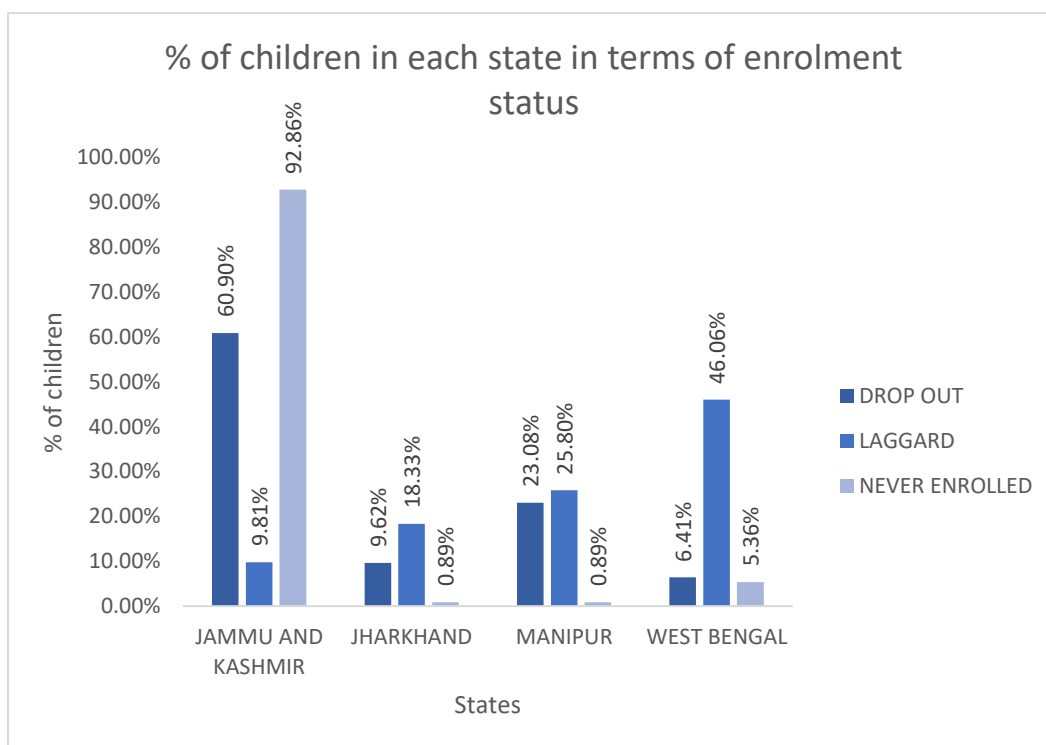


Figure 7

The pie diagram represents the percentage of each enrolment status. Figure 7 shows that most children in Jammu and Kashmir was never enrolled in schools. The rate of 'not enrolled' category is extremely high as compared to the other states which is concerning. Also, 'dropout' category has the highest contribution from the state of Jammu and Kashmir.

Table 6

Row Labels	Column Labels		Grand Total
	DROP OUT	NEVER ENROLLED	
DELAY IN ADMISSION		3	3
DIFFERENTLY ABLED	1		1
DUE TO DEATH OF FATHER	1		1
DUE TO FATHER S ILLNESS	2		2
DUE TO ILLNESS	2		2
DUE TO MIGRATION	1		1
FAMILY MIGRATION	2		2
FATHERS DEATH	3	5	8
IGNORANCE OF PARENTS		3	3
ILLNESS	1		1
INVOLVED IN DOMESTIC CHORES	1	1	2

INVOLVED IN HOUSEHOLD CHORES	1	1	2
INVOLVED IN LABOUR	1		1
LAC OF PARENTAL CONCERN		2	2
LACK OF FAMILY CONCERN		1	1
LACK OF FAMILY SUPPORT	6	9	15
LACK OF INTEREST	41	20	61
LACK OF PARENTAL CONCERN	16	50	66
LACK OF PARENTAL SUPPORT		5	5
LACK OF PROPER GUIDANCE		1	1
MIGRATION		1	1
MOTHERS DEATH	2		2
PARENTAL IGNORANCE		1	1
PHYSICALLY CHALLENGED	1		1
POVERTY	11		11
SLOW LEARNER	2		2
VISUALLY IMPAIRED		1	1
Grand Total	95	104	199

The table shows the causes of dropouts and not enrolling children in school as collected in the state of **Jammu and Kashmir**. Most of the dropouts' cases are due to lack of interest, negligence of parents and due to poverty. Causes for not enrolling are highly due to parent negligence and lack of interest. Due to closure of schools, most of the children discontinued their education and they did not get much family support as majority of them belong to the first-generation learner family as deduced from the parents' occupation.

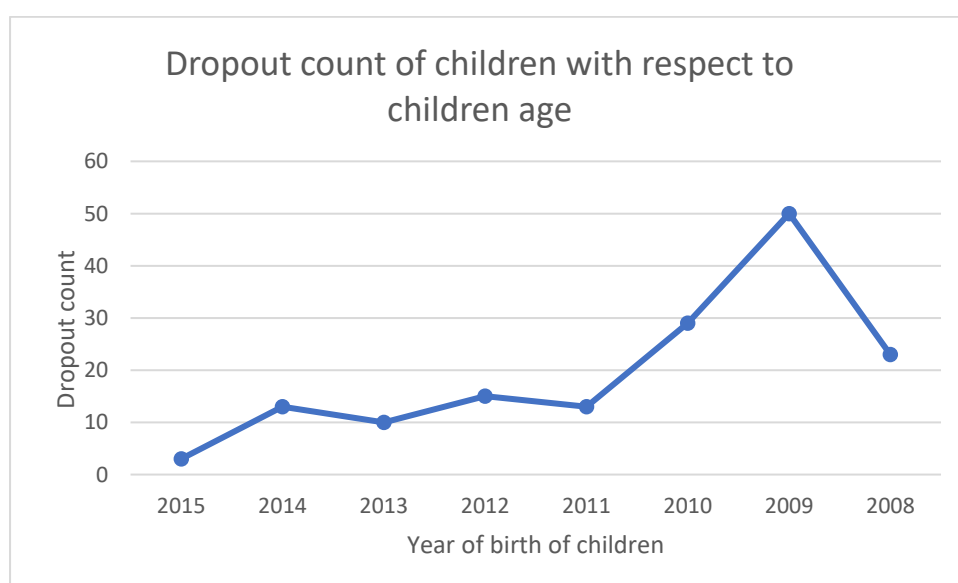


Figure 8

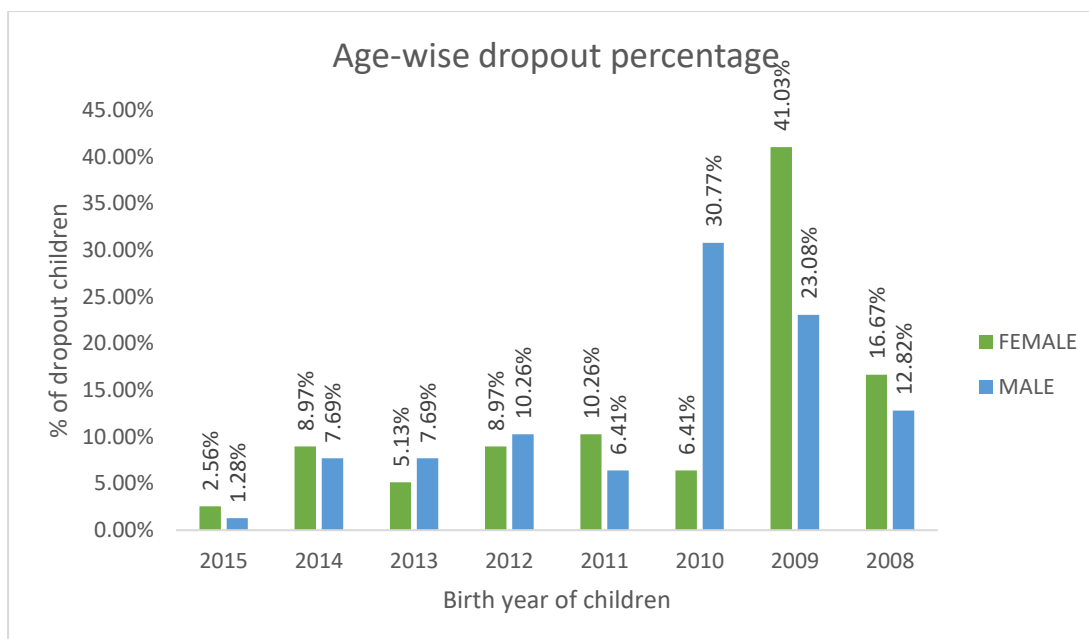


Figure 9

The birth year as denoted in figures is used to calculate age and thereby the age-appropriate class of the children. The children having been born in the year 2008 is of 14 years of age and therefore have an age-appropriate class of 8 in the year 2022. Similarly, children being born in 2015 are of class 1 in the year 2022.

Based on this observation, in the figure 8 above, we see a sharp rise after the birth year 2011. That is the period that has maximum students dropping out from their institutions which is at the age of 13 years where male students are registered with 23.08% and females with a percentage of 41.03%. The dropout level is also quite high for the children born in the year 2010, especially males.

This is the age of transition from primary school to the high school. It seems that most of them have not enrolled in the secondary education phase and have simply got out of education. In most cases it is due to the schools being far away from the hamlets. Schools being closed during covid also serve as a hindrance in getting admission to the secondary education phase as some schools serve only elementary or primary education.

As most children are considered a first-generation learner, their parents think that receiving primary education is adequate and that the children must indulge themselves in household chores or they walk the same occupational paths as their parents. Besides all these, poverty plays a major role in children remaining uneducated. As a result, most dropout cases are observed in this stage.

Compatibility Level

In figure 6, we have seen that, out of these 4000 children 93.30% children are ‘laggard’ which means that their educational level is not up to their age-appropriate classes.

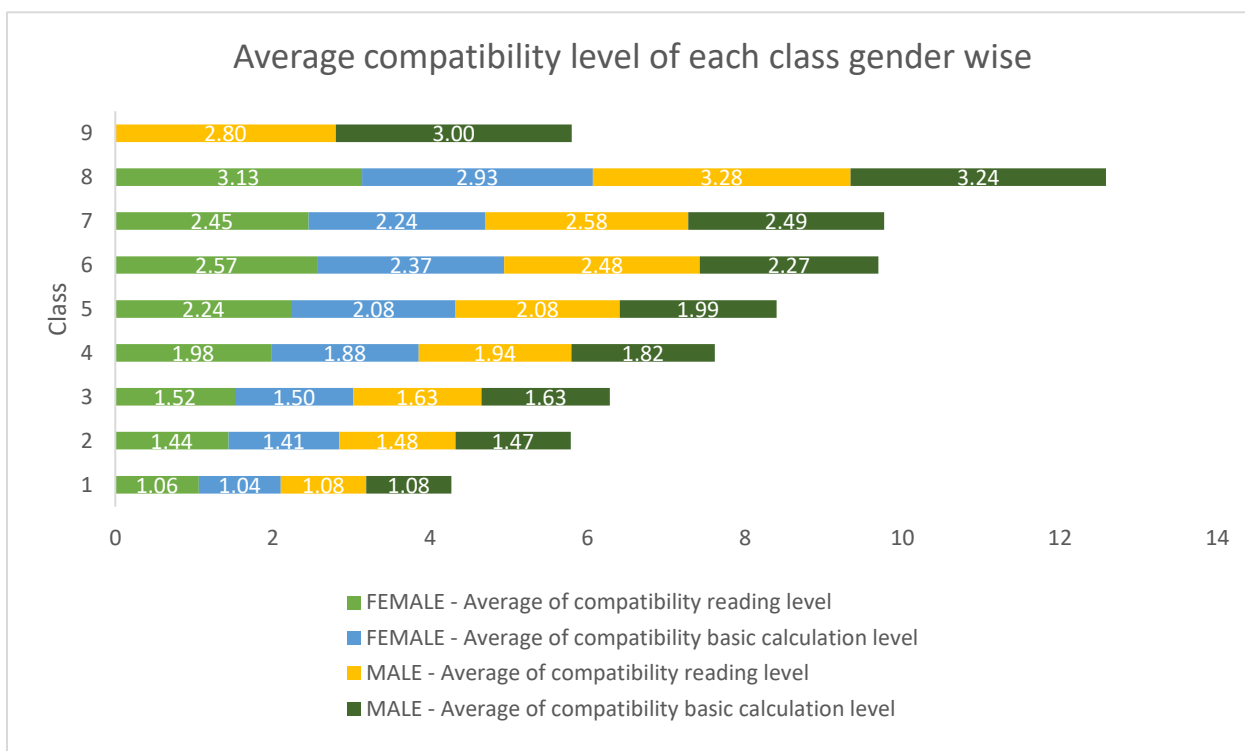


Figure 10

Compatibility level refers to the class or level for which a child is suitable or appropriate based on knowledge or skills. Here, compatibility of each of 4000 children has been tested and the results are recorded. The level of compatibility is tested based on ‘basic calculations’ and ‘reading’ skills. Figure 10 plots the average compatibility level of each class of students.

The graph indicates that higher the class, higher is the learning loss is to be noticed among the children. If we look at the bar of class 8, we see that the average reading compatibility is 3.28 for males and 3.13 for female children, whereas for basic calculation, it is slightly lower than the reading compatibility. They are not even reaching standard 4. Similarly, if we look at the bar of class 5, they are more or less at par with the 2nd standard learning level. These are the learning gaps among the rural children. The loss registered is almost the same gender wise. On the later parts we will be looking into much details.

Categorization of Learning Level

The learning level is categorized into four categories.

- Excellent : Level with age-appropriate class
- Good : Level with one year behind with age-appropriate class
- Moderate : Level with two years behind with age-appropriate class
- Poor : Level with more than two years behind with age-appropriate class

Table 7

Row Labels	Level of reading ability	Level of calculation skills
EXCELLENT	57	31
GOOD	310	158
MODERATE	635	687
POOR	2998	3124
Grand Total	4000	4000

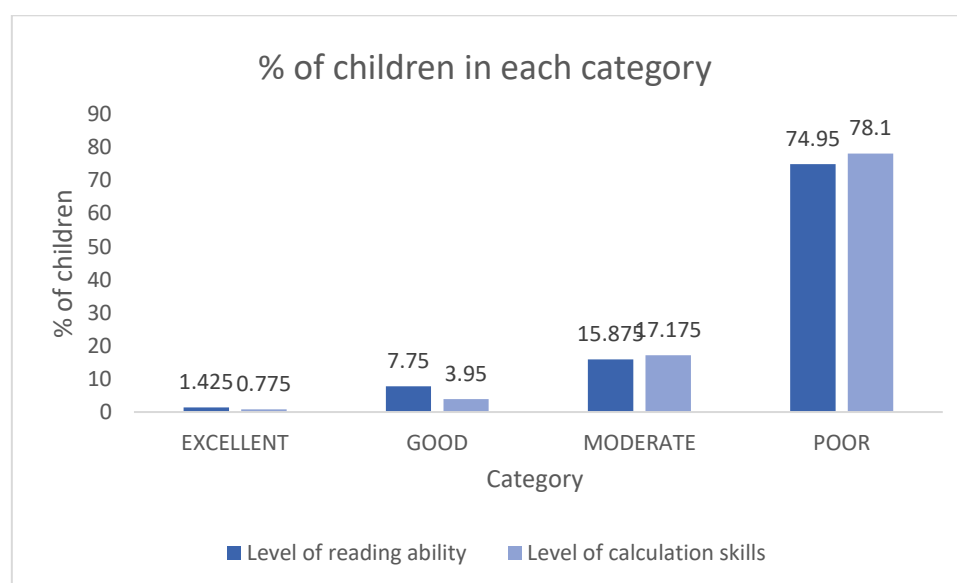


Figure 11

The table above shows the count of children in each of the categories for the level of their reading ability and their basic calculation skills. The same data is graphically represented in figure 11 in the form of percentage (base 4000 children).

The graphical diagram shows that more than 75% of the children lie under the 'Poor' category in basic calculation level and almost touching 75% in reading ability level. This means that the students lying under this category have a gap of

more than two years of learning compatibility with respect to their age-appropriate classes.

Table 8

Age-appropriate class	Category for level of basic calculation				Grand Total
	EXCELLENT	GOOD	MODERATE	POOR	
1			4	105	109
2	1	19	73	436	529
3	4	19	98	449	570
4	4	20	96	520	640
5	2	18	95	456	571
6	7	21	130	423	581
7	12	43	118	483	656
8	1	17	72	249	339
9		1	1	3	5
Grand Total	31	158	687	3124	4000

Table 9

Age-appropriate class	Category for level of reading ability				Grand Total
	EXCELLENT	GOOD	MODERATE	POOR	
1		3	1	105	109
2	20	32	52	425	529
3	8	55	67	440	570
4	6	43	77	514	640
5	2	43	87	439	571
6	7	40	129	405	581
7	13	70	135	438	656
8	1	22	87	229	339
9		2		3	5
Grand Total	57	310	635	2998	4000

From the above tables, we see that the children of higher classes are more lagging behind than those of the lower classes. The children under this category are in dire need of knowledge input as well as familial support, to be able to keep up to their appropriate knowledge level. Children at lower classes have more probability of catching up to their classes if properly trained and supported as because their educational gap is much less than that of higher classes.

Comparison of State wise Learning Level

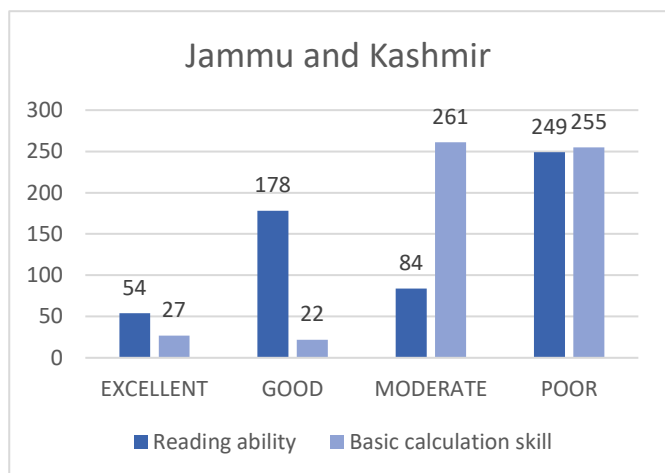


Figure 12

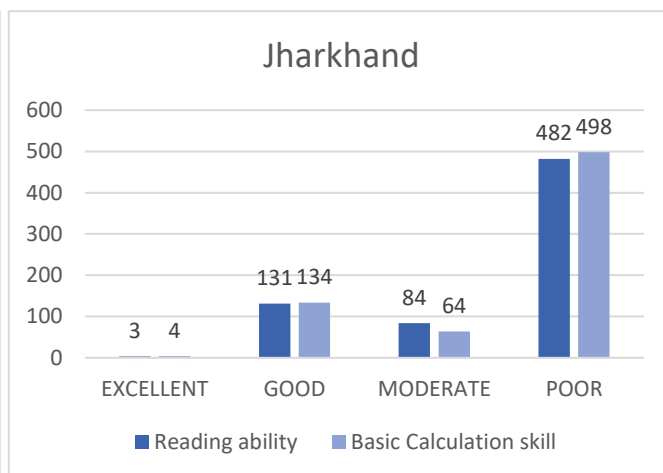


Figure 13

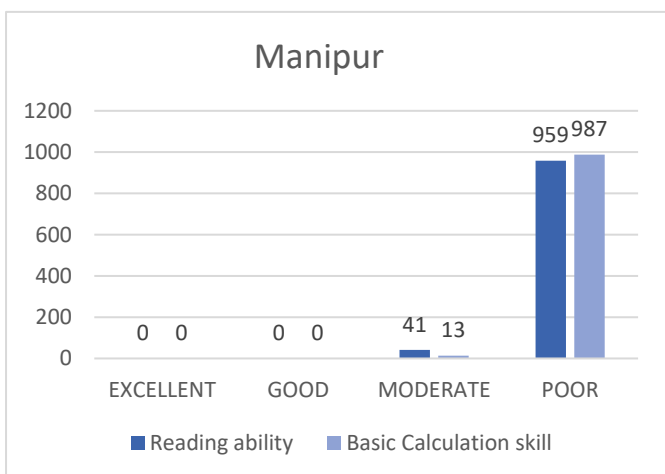


Figure 14

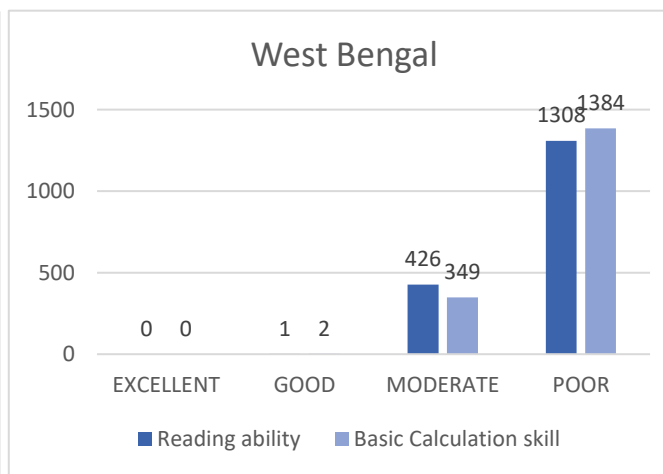


Figure 15

The four graphical diagrams are the representations of learning level of four different states. The category 'Poor' has the higher entries in all four states. In Jharkhand, Manipur and West Bengal, only the Poor categories have significantly higher values while the other categories show much lesser entries. Jammu and Kashmir has a slightly different diagram. Here the categories – Excellent, Good and Moderate have comparatively higher counts than the other three states. Therefore, this state has fewer concerning situations than the others even by very small degrees.

Learning Status of Class-8 Children

According to Indian education System, class 8 marks the end of the upper primary phase. Hereby, it makes an important milestone in a students journey of education.

Table 10

Learning Level	Reading Compatibility		Basic Calculation Compatibility		% of class 8 children (of 4000)
	Female	Male	Female	Male	
8	0	0	0	1	8.475
7	0	2	1	3	
6	4	6	1	5	
5	6	4	6	3	
4	45	28	24	23	
3	42	42	56	37	
2	54	33	47	39	
1	41	32	57	36	
Total	192	147	192	147	339

Gender wise % of children learning levels in class 8 (age-appropriate class)

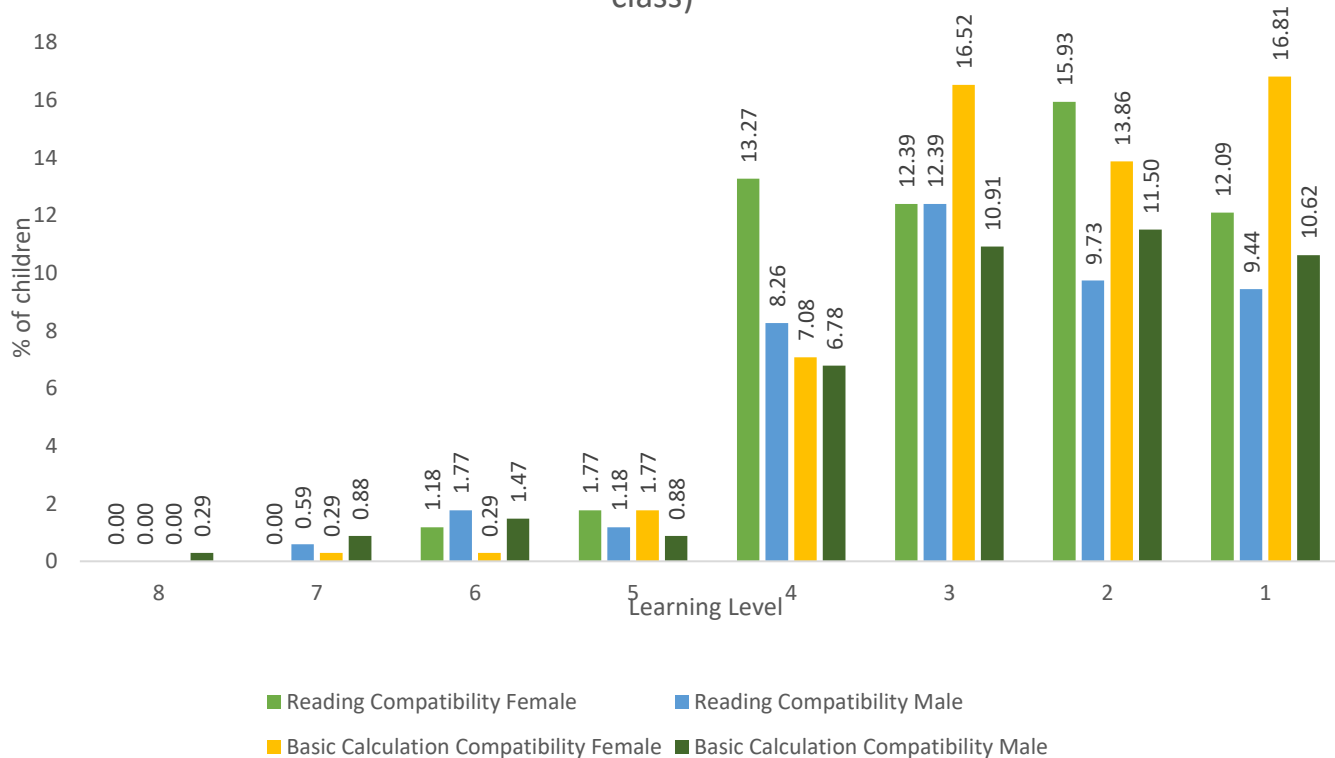


Figure 16

The table shows the count of class 8 children according to their learning level. The same information is mapped graphically in the form of percentage of all the class 8 students, in figure 16.

According to the graph, only around 6% children of 8th standard are lagging behind by two to three years in both reading and basic level calculation compatibility. Remaining (nearly 94%) children of class 8th standard has their learning levels abruptly distributed among class 1 - 4. These children whose level of education is less than that of class 4, lack basic calculation principles such as multiplication, division or three digits multiplication. They also have poor to almost no reading abilities or are unable to make a proper sensible sentence.

Learning Status of Class-5 Children

We have also made a thorough analysis on the learning status of class 5 children. 5th standard also marks an important milestone in a student's educational journey as it serves as a transition phase from primary school to upper primary or high school.

Table 11

Learning Level	Reading Compatibility		Basic Calculation Compatibility		% of class 5 children (of 4000)
	Female	Male	Female	Male	
5	3	4	3	3	14.275
4	6	2	9	2	
3	68	52	36	37	
2	128	95	138	112	
1	103	110	122	109	
Total	308	263	308	263	571

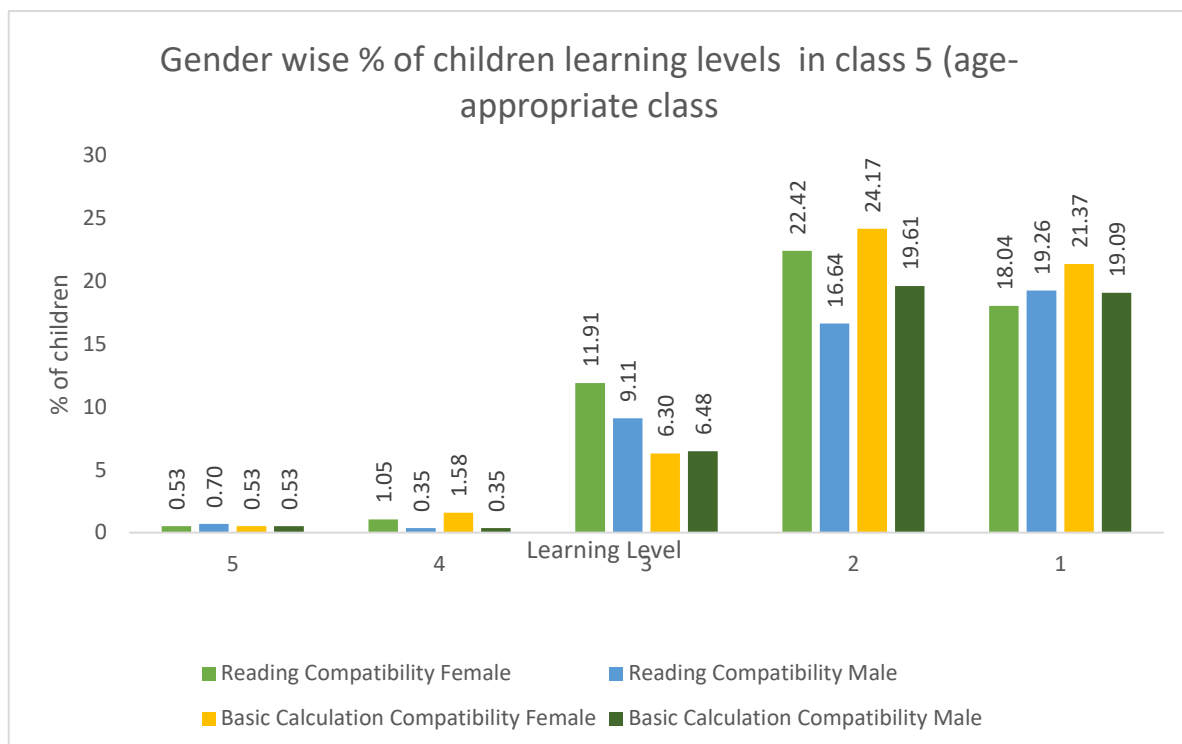


Figure 17

Similar to the analysis of class 8 children, here we observe that more or less 3% of the population of class 5 are eligible for learning in class 5 or are lagging for only a year. Around 97% children are having gaps of 3 or more years which is a huge gap. However, class 5 children can catch up to their class level much easily than that of class 8 children.

Conclusion

In our project, we used the recorded data of 4000 children after the Covid-19 breakdown. Through our analysis, we can observe that more than 50% of these children lack the basic knowledge that they should have. In conclusion, the analysis of children dropping out of school and students lacking age-appropriate knowledge underscores the multifaceted challenges that education systems face, particularly in the context of ensuring universal access, quality, and equity in learning.

The reasons for dropout are diverse. The covid has made human homeless, jobless and vulnerable. The schools and institutions were closed and the children were deprived of the education. While certain schools held online classes, rural children had no access to that and were forced to stay back home.

Covid saw the death of millions of people. Many families have lost their only earning member. Henceforth, the children were forced to take up chores or jobs to feed their family instead of studying, resulting in the huge number of dropouts.

Socio-economical reason stand a great point in lagging of education. Still today, many girl children in the remote villages are not encouraged to study. Many people believe that learning up to class 5 or class 8 is enough and that children need no further studies. Such beliefs must be eradicated. Support and encouragement of family is the most important force that is needed to educate today's generation.

Adult literacy is a necessity to educate the next generation children. India's literacy rate is 77.70%. Our country houses the highest number of adult non-literate in the world. India can become totally literate when its adult non-literacy is eradicated. i.e, becomes literate and only then the literacy rate will rise beyond 90%.

In conclusion, addressing the challenges of children dropping out of school and students lacking age-appropriate knowledge requires a comprehensive approach. The multifaceted issues, rooted in socio-economic factors, inadequate infrastructure, and systemic issues, highlight the need for targeted strategies. Initiatives should encompass community engagement, economic support, awareness campaigns, and infrastructure development.

The overarching goal is to create an inclusive education system, ensuring universal access, quality, and equity. Success relies on collaboration between government bodies, educational institutions, communities, and stakeholders to build a foundation for a more equitable and accessible educational landscape.

References

I have used the following websites for the completion of the project.

1. CRY India (Child Rights and You): www.cry.org
2. RILM (Rotary India Literacy Mission): www.rotaryteach.com
3. OSAAT (One School At A Time): www.osaat.org
4. Wikipedia: <https://en.wikipedia.org>